



Team man: K. L. Rahul, a recurring casualty of batting-order rejigs, may be shunted to No. 4 just as he was finding his feet again as an opener. AP

surrounding the batting order, the only constant for the team will be the lack of experience. Not since the twin retirements of Rahul Dravid and V.V.S Laxman after the disastrous tour of Australia in 2012 has the team been as thin on batting resources. And back then, Kohli and Cheteshwar Pujara had proven themselves adequately to lend spine to the line-up, even as Tendulkar's towering stature loomed over them.

The current India Test setup affords no such sanctuary. Jaiswal is yet to play a Test in England, Gill has a point to prove overseas, Rahul needs to pin down his position, Sudharsan is bracing for a debut, and Rishabh Pant is battling poor form and a lack of clarity. In short, India's potential top five are in the wilderness and the most immediate challenge will be cohesion and not betraying the sense of the upcoming

series being a tryout for individual survival.

The middle order could turn to Ravindra Jadeja, who with 80 matches under his belt is the most battle-hardened in the current Test setup. The all-rounder's batting stocks have dipped in the recent past and he may have to do more than just chip in with cameos, especially in overseas conditions.

At the crossroads

The WTC era in Test cricket has infused the need for a restart every time a new cycle beckons. With Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane being sidelined for almost two years, a comeback is unlikely. The duo has done its part by doing the hard yards in domestic cricket and the County Championship and keeping rust at bay, but the management seems to have moved on from them. Pujara and Rahane are the only active players with some experience at No. 4, having played seven and nine games respectively in that position. They could help smoothen the transition and imbue the younger crop with their never-say-die spirit, but that ship seems to have sailed.

That Jaiswal and Nitish Kumar Reddy were India's most successful batters in the 2024-25 Border-Gavaskar Trophy perhaps only reinforces the belief that experience is overvalued. That notion will be challenged imminently. As much as the term 'end of an era' is too often profaned, going by how generously it is thrown around in pop culture references, Rohit and Kohli's departure from Test cricket truly signifies an inflection point.

The years that will follow will be grouped under the 'post Rohit-Kohli era', much like the period that ensued after Dravid, Laxman and Tendulkar walked into the sunset. With their contrasting styles and fortunes in whites, Rohit and Kohli carved a sacred space for the game even as the swathes of franchise cricket expanded endlessly. It is for the next generation to safeguard that territory and ensure the Rohit-Kohli era is not reduced to a wistful memory.